‘You are not a fabrication expert,’ Sasi shot at me.

‘Go tell that to Dhawan who put me in this chair.’

End of conversation. Sasi’s proposal was rejected.

Common friends and colleagues told me that it was good that Sasi and I did not work in the same unit, for it would mean constant scuffles. I had a bad temper; Sasi had a knack of picking fights with just anyone. Working on different projects, however, we managed to maintain truce.

At a meeting of Viking engine after the first PSLV launch in 1993, Sasi had a difference of opinion with an IAS officer named Sengupta, who was a joint secretary at the department of space. Sengupta had suggested that Sasi would not understand the financial implication of a proposal we were discussing. Sasi lost his cool.

‘Yes, I don’t know the financial implication,’ he said. ‘And you, Mr Sengupta, don’t understand a damn thing about engineering.’

Sengupta was to nurse this insult for some time to come. The next year, when police came knocking at Sasi’s door after Mariyam Rasheeda’s arrest in October 1994, Sengupta was instrumental in transferring Sasi to the Satellite Application Centre (SAC), Ahmedabad. This amounted to ISRO conceding that its scientist could have done something wrong. It also reflects on the poor judgment of R Kasturirangan, the ISRO chairman.

Curiously, former IB Joint Director M K Dhar, who was instrumental in propounding the ISRO spy story, mentions in his book *Open Secrets* about a ‘Bangalore-based joint secretary of the department of space, who happened to be a Bengali,’ visiting him to appreciate the progress of the investigation into the ISRO spy case.

It was during the indigenisation drive after the successful ground test of Vikas in 1985 that I established a functional rapport with Sasi. When we had to get a cobalt alloy made by MIDHANI in Hyderabad, I had taken help from Sasi who was already interacting the company on behalf of Abdul Kalam to get maraging steel for SLV-3, which was flown successfully in July 1980.

Though we never became close friends, I started seeing Sasi with some respect after he brought around MIDHANI to work for us. Sasi should be